PADHAKU
First Flight · Class 10 English



CHAPTER 6

Mijbil the Otter

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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⭐ Mijbil the Otter · Before You Read

2 **Imagine someone has gifted you a pet. With your partner's help, make a list of the things you need to know about the pet in order to take good care of it. One has been done for you: (i) The food it eats.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

(i) The food it eats.

(ii) How often it needs a bath and grooming.

(iii) The vaccinations it needs and the name of a good vet.

(iv) How much exercise and play it needs every day.

(v) Where it will sleep and how to toilet-train it.

3 **Imagine you wanted to bring an otter from Iraq to London, as a pet. What special arrangements would you need to make for your pet otter? You would need to find a place with lots of water, for example. What other points should you think about?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

- A place with lots of water: a pond, tub or large bath where it can swim and play.
- Fresh fish and the right food, as it may be hard to get in a busy city.

- A warm, dry shelter, because London is cooler and wetter than the hot, dry plains of Iraq.
- Permission (licence) to import the animal, health checks and vaccinations.
- A safe box/cage and the airline's rules for carrying an animal on the flight.
- Space to exercise: walks on a lead in London's parks and open spaces.
- Keeping it safe from traffic and crowds in a very busy city.

⭐ Mijbil the Otter · Oral Comprehension Check (I–II)

1 **What 'experiment' did Maxwell think Camusfearna would be suitable for?**

✔ ANSWER

Maxwell wanted to keep an **otter as a pet instead of a dog**. He thought Camusfearna, "ringed by water a stone's throw from its door", would be an eminently suitable spot for this experiment.

2 **Why does he go to Basra? How long does he wait there, and why?**

✔ ANSWER

He went to Basra, to the Consulate-General, **to collect and answer his mail from Europe**. His friend's mail had come but his had not, so he waited. He cabled England and tried to telephone, and his mail finally came **after about eight days** (three days, then five more).

3 **How does he get the otter? Does he like it? Pick out the words that tell you this.**

✔ ANSWER

His friend sent the otter in a sack with **two Arabs**, who were waiting in Maxwell's bedroom with a note: "Here is your otter..."

Yes, he liked it very much. The words that show this: "a phase of my life that has not yet ended", "a **thraldom to otters**, an **otter fixation**".

4 **Why was the otter named 'Maxwell's otter'?**

✔ ANSWER

Mijbil belonged to **a race previously unknown to science**. Since Maxwell brought it to notice, zoologists named it *Lutrogale perspicillata maxwelli*, or **Maxwell's otter**, after him.

5 **Tick the right answer. In the beginning, the otter was - aloof and indifferent - friendly - hostile**

✔ ANSWER

Aloof and indifferent. For the first twenty-four hours Mijbil was “neither hostile nor friendly”; he slept on the floor as far from Maxwell’s bed as possible.

6 **What happened when Maxwell took Mijbil to the bathroom? What did it do two days after that?**

✔ ANSWER

In the bathroom Mijbil **went wild with joy** in the water for half an hour, plunging, rolling, shooting up and down the bathtub underwater and making “enough slosh and splash for a hippo”.

Two days later he **escaped from the bedroom, ran to the bathroom**, climbed on the bathtub and **turned the tap** with his paws until he got a full flow of water.

⭐ Mijbil the Otter · Oral Comprehension Check (III)

1 **How was Mij to be transported to England?**

✔ ANSWER

The British airline would not fly animals, so Maxwell booked a flight to **Paris on another airline, and from there to London**. Mij had to be packed in **a box not more than eighteen inches square**, kept on the floor at Maxwell's feet.

2 **What did Mij do to the box?**

✔ ANSWER

Mij **tore the lining of the box to shreds**, trying to get out. He hurt himself, and blood trickled out from the airholes and chinks around the lid.

3 **Why did Maxwell put the otter back in the box? How do you think he felt when he did this?**

✔ ANSWER

There were **only ten minutes left before the flight** and the airport was five miles away, and the airline allowed Mij only in the box. So he removed the torn lining and put Mij back, holding the lid down with his hand.

He must have felt **sad, guilty and helpless** to put the "miserable Mij", already hurt and frightened, back in the box.

4 **Why does Maxwell say the airhostess was "the very queen of her kind"?**

✔ ANSWER

The air hostess was very **kind, understanding and helpful**. She kept Mij's fish in a cool place, let Maxwell keep his pet on his knee, and later, with a charming smile, offered to find the runaway otter herself. So Maxwell admired her deeply.

5 **What happened when the box was opened?**

✔ ANSWER

- Mij was **out of the box in a flash** and ran at high speed down the aircraft.
- There were squawks and shrieks; a woman stood on her seat screaming, "A rat! A rat!"
- Maxwell dived for Mij's tail under a portly Indian's legs, missed, and got his **face covered in curry**.
- The air hostess asked him to sit down. Soon Mij came back, **bounded on to his knee and nuzzled his face and neck**.

⭐ Mijbil the Otter · Oral Comprehension Check (IV)

1 **What game had Mij invented?**

✔ ANSWER

Mij used a **ping-pong ball on the sloping lid of a damaged suitcase**. He placed the ball on the high end, let it roll down, dashed to the other end to ambush it, grabbed it and trotted back to the high end. It kept him busy for up to half an hour.

2 **What are 'compulsive habits'? What does Maxwell say are the compulsive habits of (i) school children (ii) Mij?**

✔ ANSWER

Compulsive habits are habits that are impossible to control.

(i) **School children**, on their way to and from school, must place their feet squarely on the centre of each paving block, touch every seventh upright of the iron railings, or pass to the outside of every second lamp post.

(ii) **Mij**, on his way home (never on his way out), would tug Maxwell to the low wall of a primary school, jump on it and gallop its full thirty yards.

3 **What group of animals do otters belong to?**

✔ ANSWER

Otters belong to a small group of animals called **Mustellines**, shared by the badger, mongoose, weasel, stoat, mink and others.

4 **What guesses did the Londoners make about what Mij was?**

✔ ANSWER

Londoners guessed every animal but the otter: **a baby seal, a squirrel, a walrus, a hippo, a beaver, a bear cub, a leopard and a 'brontosaur'**. A labourer asked, "Here, Mister — what is that supposed to be?"

🤔 Mijbil the Otter · Thinking about the Text

1 **What things does Mij do which tell you that he is an intelligent, friendly and fun-loving animal who needs love?**

✔ ANSWER

- **Intelligent:** he learnt to turn the bathroom tap on; he invented a game with a ping-pong ball on the sloping suitcase lid.
- **Friendly / needs love:** on the second night he slept in the crook of Maxwell's knees; he followed Maxwell without a lead and came when called; in the plane he came back with "a chitter of recognition and welcome" and nuzzled Maxwell's face and neck.
- **Fun-loving:** he played wildly in water, dribbled a rubber ball like a soccer player, juggled marbles on his belly, and galloped along the school wall.

2 **What are some of the things we come to know about otters from this text?**

✔ ANSWER

- Otters love water: every drop must be spread about; a bowl must be overturned or sat in.
- They are playful: they juggle small objects such as marbles on their back between their paws.
- They are intelligent and can be tamed; Arabs in the Tigris marshes often tamed them.
- They are common in the Tigris marshes of Iraq.
- They belong to the Mustelline group (with the badger, mongoose, weasel, stoat, mink).
- Most people who own an otter develop an 'otter fixation'.

3 **Why is Mij's species now known to the world as Maxwell's otter?**

✔ ANSWER

Mij was of **a race previously unknown to science**. It became known through Maxwell, so zoologists named it *Lutrogale perspicillata maxwelli*, or **Maxwell's otter**.

4 **Maxwell in the story speaks for the otter, Mij. He tells us what the otter feels and thinks on different occasions. Complete the column on**

the right to say what Maxwell says about what Mij feels and thinks.

What Mij does	How Mij feels or thinks
plunges, rolls in the water and makes the water splosh and splash	?
Screws the tap in the wrong way	?
Nuzzles Maxwell's face and neck in the aeroplane	?

✔ ANSWER

What Mij does	How Mij feels or thinks
Plunges, rolls in the water and makes it splosh and splash	He is **wild with joy**. He feels water must be kept on the move and made to do things; when static it is "wasted and provoking".
Screws the tap in the wrong way	He feels **irritated and disappointed** ("chittering with irritation and disappointment") at the tap's failure to cooperate.
Nuzzles Maxwell's face and neck in the aeroplane	He feels **relieved and happy** to find his master after being frightened; a "distressed chitter of recognition and welcome" shows his love.

5 **Read the story and find the sentences where Maxwell describes his pet otter. Then choose and arrange your sentences to illustrate those statements below that you think are true. Maxwell's description**

(i) makes Mij seem almost human, like a small boy.

(ii) shows that he is often irritated with what Mij does.

(iii) shows that he is often surprised by what Mij does.

(iv) of Mij's antics is comical.

(v) shows that he observes the antics of Mij very carefully.

(vi) shows that he thinks Mij is a very ordinary otter.

(vii) shows that he thinks the otter is very unusual.

✔ ANSWER

True: (i), (iii), (iv), (v), (vii). False: (ii), (vi).

(i) Almost human: "He spent hours shuffling a rubber ball round the room like a four-footed soccer player"; his habits on walks are "like the rituals of children".

(iii) Surprised: "I watched, amazed; in less than a minute he had turned the tap..."; he threw the ball "to a surprising height and distance".

(iv) Comical: "making enough slosh and splash for a hippo"; "a bowl must... be sat in and sploshed in until it overflows".

(v) Observes carefully: "he would lie on his back rolling two or more of them up and down his wide, flat belly without ever dropping one to the floor."

(vii) Very unusual: “Mijbil… was, in fact, of a race previously unknown to science”; he “resembled… a very small, medievally-conceived, dragon”.

(ii) is false: Maxwell is never irritated; he enjoys Mij. (vi) is false: he finds Mij special, not ordinary.

🤔 Mijbil the Otter · Thinking about Language

I **Describing a Repeated Action in the Past. From the table below, make as many correct sentences as you can using would and/or used to, as appropriate. Then add two or three sentences of your own.**

Emperor Akbar / Every evening we / Fifty years ago, very few people / Till the 1980s, Shanghai / My uncle — would / used to — be fond of musical evenings / take long walks on the beach / own cars / have very dirty streets / spend his holidays by the sea.

✔ ANSWER

1. Emperor Akbar **used to** be fond of musical evenings. (state)
2. Every evening we **would / used to** take long walks on the beach. (action)
3. Fifty years ago, very few people **used to** own cars. (state)
4. Till the 1980s, Shanghai **used to** have very dirty streets. (situation)

5. My uncle **would / used to** spend his holidays by the sea. (action)

Sentences of my own (sample):

- As a child, I would sit with my grandmother and listen to her stories.
- My father used to live in a small village.
- We used to believe that the old house was haunted.

II.1 **Look at these examples from the text, and say whether the modifiers (in italics) are nouns, proper nouns, or adjective plus noun.**

(i) An otter fixation (ii) The iron railings (iii) The Tigris marshes (iv) The London streets (v) soft velvet fur (vi) A four-footed soccer player

✔ ANSWER

(i) otter fixation – **noun**

(ii) iron railings – **noun**

(iii) Tigris marshes – **proper noun**

(iv) London streets – **proper noun**

(v) soft velvet fur – **adjective plus noun**

(vi) four-footed soccer player – **adjective plus noun**

II.2 **Given below are some nouns, and a set of modifiers (in the box). Combine the nouns and modifiers to make as many appropriate phrases as you can.**

Nouns: temple, girls, triangle, dresses, person, thoughts, boys, roar, gifts, scream, farewell, expression, time, subject, landscape, handkerchief, crossing, flight, chatterbox, profession, physique, coffee, view, celebration

Modifiers: college, rough, hundred, stone, ordinary, love, uncomfortable, white, slang, slack, bare, railroad, tremendous, family, marriage, plump, invigorating, panoramic, heartbreaking, birthday, incorrigible, ridiculous, loud, first, three

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Possible phrases:

- college girls, college boys
- rough landscape
- hundred dresses
- stone temple
- ordinary person
- love triangle
- uncomfortable thoughts, uncomfortable subject
- white handkerchief
- slang expression
- slack time
- bare landscape
- railroad crossing
- tremendous roar
- family profession
- marriage celebration

- plump physique
- invigorating coffee
- panoramic view
- heartbreaking farewell
- birthday gifts, birthday celebration
- incorrigible chatterbox
- ridiculous expression
- loud scream
- first flight
- three girls, three boys

III.1 **Match the words on the left with a word on the right. Some words on the left can go with more than one word on the right.**

(i) a portion of (ii) a pool of (iii) flakes of (iv) a huge heap of (v) a gust of (vi) little drops of (vii) a piece of (viii) a pot of

blood, cotton, stones, gold, fried fish, snow, water, wind

✔ ANSWER

(i) a portion of – **fried fish**

(ii) a pool of – **blood / water**

(iii) flakes of – **snow**

(iv) a huge heap of – **stones**

(v) a gust of – **wind**

(vi) little drops of – **water / blood**

(vii) a piece of – **cotton**

(viii) a pot of – **gold**

III.2 **Use a bit of/a piece of/a bunch of/a cloud of/a lump of with the italicised nouns in the following sentences. (i) My teacher gave me some advice. → My teacher gave me a bit of advice.**

(ii) Can you give me some clay, please.

(iii) The information you gave was very useful.

(iv) Because of these factories, smoke hangs over the city.

(v) Two stones rubbed together can produce sparks of fire.

(vi) He gave me some flowers on my birthday.

✔ ANSWER

(ii) Can you give me **a lump of** clay, please.

(iii) **The bit of** information you gave was very useful. (or: The piece of information...)

(iv) Because of these factories, **a cloud of** smoke hangs over the city.

(v) Two stones rubbed together can produce **a bit of** fire.

(vi) He gave me **a bunch of** flowers on my birthday.

⭐ Mijbil the Otter · Speaking

1 **You have seen how Maxwell describes Mij the otter's feelings and thoughts by watching**

him. Play the game of dumb charades. Take turns to express a feeling or thought silently, through gestures. Let the class speak out their guesses about the feelings or thoughts you are trying to express.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Points for the game:

- **Joy:** wide smile, clapping, jumping.
- **Anger:** frown, clenched fists, stamping the foot.
- **Fear:** wide eyes, hands over the mouth, stepping back.
- **Sadness:** head down, wiping pretend tears.
- **Surprise:** raised eyebrows, open mouth, hands on cheeks.
- **Boredom / impatience:** yawning, tapping fingers, looking at the watch.

The class guesses each feeling; the one who guesses right takes the next turn.

⭐ Mijbil the Otter · Writing

1 **Write a description of a person or an animal (such as a pet) that you know very well and love very much. Mention some things the person or animal does, what you think the person or animal feels, etc.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

My Dog Bruno

Bruno, my brown Labrador, is three years old and the darling of our family. He has soft, shiny fur, floppy ears and big, honey-coloured eyes. Every morning he wakes me by licking my hand, as if to say, "Get up, it's time for our walk!"

When I come back from school, he runs to the gate and wags his tail so hard that his whole body shakes. I think he feels lonely without me all day. He loves to chase a ball and drop it at my feet again and again, never getting tired.

When I am scolded and sit quietly, Bruno puts his head on my lap. He seems to understand that I am sad. He is afraid of thunder and hides under my bed. Bruno is not just a pet; he is my best friend.

🤔 Fog · Thinking about the Poem

1(i) What does Sandburg think the fog is like?

✔ ANSWER

Sandburg thinks the fog is **like a cat**: it comes silently, sits and watches, and then moves on.

1(ii) How does the fog come?

✔ ANSWER

The fog comes **"on little cat feet"**: silently and slowly, without being noticed.

1(iii) **What does ‘it’ in the third line refer to?**

✔ ANSWER

‘It’ refers to **the fog**.

1(iv) **Does the poet actually say that the fog is like a cat? Find three things that tell us that the fog is like a cat.**

✔ ANSWER

No, the poet does not say so directly; he uses a **metaphor**.

Three things that show the fog is like a cat:

- It comes “on little cat feet” (silently).
- It sits looking over harbour and city “on silent haunches”.
- It “then moves on”, quietly, as a cat does.

2(i) **Find metaphors for the following words and complete the table below. Also try to say how they are alike. The first is done for you.**

Word	Metaphor	How they are alike
Storm	tiger	pounces over the fields, growls
Train		
Fire		
School		
Home		

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Word	Metaphor	How they are alike
Storm	tiger	pounces over the fields, growls
Train	snake	long body, winds along the track, hisses
Fire	hungry monster / dragon	devours everything, roars, spits flames
School	beehive	full of busy, humming children
Home	nest	warm, safe shelter where we are cared for

2(ii) **Think about a storm. Try to visualise the force of the storm, hear the sound of the storm, feel the power of the storm and the sudden calm that happens afterwards. Write**

a poem about the storm comparing it with an animal.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

The Storm

The storm is a tiger, black and wild,
It leaps from the hills with eyes of fire,
It growls in the clouds, it roars at the trees,
It claws at the roofs and shakes the wire.
It pounces on fields and tears at the corn,
It lashes its tail of wind and rain;
Then, tired at last, it creeps away,
And the world lies quiet and calm again.

3 **Does this poem have a rhyme scheme? Poetry that does not have an obvious rhythm or rhyme is called 'free verse'.**

✔ ANSWER

No, the poem has no rhyme scheme. It is written in **free verse**: the lines are of different lengths and have no regular rhythm or rhyme.

🎉 **Chapter 6 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**